



FITNESSWISE

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The illusion of intensity

Chasing exhaustion and complexity may feel like progress, but elite athletes know that true success depends on **mastering the basics.**

One of the most frequent narratives I hear as an S&C coach is the following declaration: “This programme isn’t advanced or tough enough for me compared to what the other players are being given.”

Most of the time, this comes from players and lifters who believe advanced training should include loads of cleans, supersets, drop sets, HIIT, circuits, and extremely high-volume, high-intensity workouts that push them to hyperventilate and even vomit. That’s what they want training to look like.

Little do they realise that while such sessions may seem glamorous and make them feel elated, reality soon strikes. When faced with a schedule that is genuinely demanding — even one that is only slightly more intense than normal — they often feel gutted, as it exceeds their imagined fitness levels. They then become either defensive or aggressive. Is this true self-awareness from the player’s side? A point to ponder.

In reality, advanced lifters and players know they are never too advanced for the basics. The main antagonists are often half-baked professionals and wannabe players asking for more without understanding what it takes to master the basics and withstand the demands of high-intensity training, which can leave them either hyperventilating or injured.

At some point, every serious lifter learns that the most effective workouts are often built around simple, fundamental movements

performed with high effort, proper form and adequate rest. For example, a workout like this might not look particularly exciting on paper:

- ◆ Lunge walk: 3 × 6-8 reps
- ◆ Incline bench press: 3 × 8-10 reps
- ◆ Stiff-leg deadlift: 3 × 6-8 reps
- ◆ Chin-up: 3 × maximum reps
- ◆ Barbell hip thrust: 3 × 10 reps

Many beginners look at a workout like this and think it isn’t challenging enough. They often prefer something like:

- ◆ Split lunge: 4 × 20 reps; superset with explosive push-up: 4 × failure
- ◆ Eccentric-accentuated stiff-leg deadlift (4-second lowering): 4 × 10 reps; superset with prone row: 4 × failure
- ◆ Iso-banded barbell hip thrust (3-second pause): 4 × 8 reps; superset with dumbbell push press: 4 × 6 reps
- ◆ Cable kneeling glute push: 4 × 12 reps; superset with wide-grip pulldown: 4 × 10 reps
- ◆ Reverse 45-degree hyperextension: 4 × 15 reps; superset with dumbbell lateral raise: 4 × 12 reps
- ◆ Multi-hip abduction triple drop set: 4 × 10 reps

But here’s the transformation. An advanced lifter performing the first workout might log numbers like:

- ◆ Walking lunge: 2 × 6 reps @ 90kg, 1 × 6 reps @ 95kg
- ◆ Incline chest press: 1 × 9 reps, 1 × 9 reps, 1 × 7 reps @ 60kg
- ◆ Stiff-leg deadlift: 2 × 8 reps, 1 × 7 reps @ 110kg
- ◆ Pull-up: 1 × 15 reps, 1 × 9 reps, 1 × 6 reps
- ◆ Supine hip thrust: 2 × 10 reps @ 150kg, 1 × 10 reps @ 160kg

After a workout like this, they’re

completely spent. They’ll most likely rest for three to four minutes between sets because heavy compound lifts require adequate recovery to produce maximal effort.

Now imagine a beginner or intermediate athlete performing the same workout without the necessary foundation. Or consider the players demanding a tougher schedule. Their workout might look like this:

- ◆ Walking lunge: 3 × 6 reps @ 20kg
- ◆ Incline press: 3 × 12 reps @ 15kg
- ◆ Stiff-leg deadlift: 3 × 8 reps @ 70kg
- ◆ Chin-up: 3 × 6 reps (assisted)
- ◆ Supine hip thrust: 3 × 6 reps @ 60kg

To them, the workout might feel too easy. They may even try to turn it into a circuit or reduce their rest periods to 60 seconds because they feel they need more ‘intensity’.

The key point is this: Beginners often get their intensity from cumulative volume. Advanced lifters get their intensity from the effort they put into every set. Early on, many players have not yet developed the coordination, strength and technique needed to extract the maximum benefit from each movement.

As those qualities improve, the very same basic exercises become significantly more demanding and far more effective. That’s why advanced lifters never abandon the basics. The basics may evolve as they progress, and each player’s foundation will differ according to the demands of their sport and individual needs.

Focusing on becoming stronger at foundational movements, refining technique and applying progressive overload over time is the right way to improve performance.